

FREE RESOURCE KIT · NO MEMBERSHIP NEEDED

DENTAL MEMBER NETWORK · FOUNDED BY THRIVING DENTIST

Negotiating Better PPO Fees

The 7-step process behind **10–35% better reimbursements** — the exact script, checklist and worksheet our members use. See the quality before you commit a cent.

Fee-Negotiation Script

Pre-Call Checklist

PPO Comparison Worksheet

Based on the work of **Ben Tuinei** & Veritas Dental Resources (9,000+ practices), packaged by the Dental Member Network.

dentalmembernetwork.com

THE HERO ASSET

The Fee-Negotiation Script

BEFORE YOU DIAL

“Have your insurance profile open: your top-40 codes, current fee schedule, and which plans you haven't negotiated in 2+ years.”

OPENING

“Hi, this is Dr. [Name], owner of [Practice]. I'm reviewing our participation with [Carrier] and I'd like to start a fee-schedule review.”

Lead as the **owner** — the contract is doctor-to-carrier, not office-to-carrier.

THE ASK

“Several of our most-used procedures no longer cover our cost of care. I'd like an increase on our top-40 codes, starting with [codes].”

Be specific and code-level — vague asks get vague answers.

SHOW YOUR LEVERAGE

“We value our [Carrier] patients, but at today's rates we're evaluating whether to stay in-network. I wanted to give you the chance to revisit our fees first.”

Only say this if you've done the math and **could actually walk**. Your leverage is being prepared to walk away.

WHEN THEY SAY "WE DON'T NEGOTIATE"

“I understand that's the standard response — in our experience every carrier reviews fees with the right documentation. Who handles provider fee-schedule reviews, and what do you need from me to begin?”

Don't accept the first "no." Persist; some carriers take several rounds over months.

DON'T FORGET THE DOWNGRADE CODES

“I also want to review the alternative-benefit / downgrade codes on [codes] — those quietly cost our patients hundreds.”

The #1 overlooked area. A crown fee can rise 40% while an un-negotiated downgrade still costs the patient.

CLOSE & FOLLOW UP

“Can you confirm the next step and a timeline? I'll send this in writing today, signed by me.”

Counter the first offer — never accept the opening number. Put it in writing, doctor-signed.

BEFORE YOU PICK UP THE PHONE

Pre-Call Checklist

Build your profile

- ☐ Gather all current PPO contracts + last-negotiated dates
- ☐ Request updated fee schedules from every carrier
- ☐ List your top-40 most-utilized procedure codes
- ☐ Map your umbrella / leasing networks
- ☐ Confirm your UCR office fees are set correctly

Negotiate

- ☐ Decide your goal: higher fees, drop plans, or restructure
- ☐ Know your patient mix per plan & your market leverage
- ☐ Have the doctor sign every letter & join the initial call
- ☐ On the first offer, check the top-40 + downgrade codes, then counter
- ☐ Don't take "we don't negotiate" for an answer — persist

Optimize

- ☐ Untangle umbrella relationships → fewest contracts, highest fees
- ☐ Consider a professional firm for legal fee data & speed

MAP YOUR PLANS & YOUR LEVERAGE

PPO Comparison Worksheet

Your Insurance Profile

Plans you're contracted with:

.....

Top-volume plan (% of patients):

.....

Plans not negotiated in 2+ years:

.....

Leverage Check

Could you afford to go out-of-network on one plan? (Y/N):

.....

Your market — saturated or underserved:

.....

Your First Move

First carrier to approach + goal %:

.....

Top-40 + downgrade codes reviewed? (Y/N):

.....

DIY or hire a pro:

.....

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